

Questions 46 to 50 are based on the following passage.

Could you get by without using the internet for four and a half years? That's exactly what singer and actress Selena Gomez has done in a bid to improve her mental health.

She has spoken extensively about the relationship between her social media usage and her mental wellbeing, recalling feeling like "an addict" when she became Instagram's most followed user in 2016. "Taking a break from social media was the best decision that I've ever made for my mental health", says she. "The unnecessary hate and comparisons went away once I put my phone down."

Ditching the web at large, however, is a far more subtle and complicated prospect. The increasing digitisation of our society means that everything from paying a gas bill to plotting a route to a friend's house and even making a phone call is at the mercy of your internet connection. Actively opting out of using the internet becomes a matter of privilege.

Ms Gomez's multi-millionaire status has allowed her to take the "social" out of social media, so she can continue to leverage her enormous fame while keeping the *trolls* (恶意挑衅的帖子) at bay. The fact that she's still the second most-followed woman on Instagram suggests it's entirely possible to maintain a significant web profile to promote various projects—by way of a dedicated team—without being exposed to the cruel comments, hate mail and rape or death threats.

It goes without saying that this is fundamentally different from how the rest of us without beauty deals and films to publicise use the likes of Instagram, TikTok and Twitter, but even the concept of a digital *detox* (戒瘾) requires having a device and connectivity to choose to disconnect from.

The UK's digital divide has worsened over the past two years, leaving poorer families without broadband connections in their homes. Digital exclusion is a major threat to wider societal equality in the UK, so witnessing companies like Facebook championing the *metaverse* (元宇宙) as the next great frontier when school children are struggling to complete their homework feels particularly irritating.

Consequently, it's worth bearing in mind that while deleting all social media accounts will undoubtedly make some feel infinitely better, many other people benefit from the strong sense of community that sharing platforms can breed.

Internet access will continue to grow in importance as we edge further towards web 3.0, and greater resources and initiatives are needed to provide the underprivileged with the connectivity they desperately need to learn, work and live. It's crucial that people who feel that social media is having a detrimental effect on their mental health are allowed to switch off and for those living in digital exclusion to be able to switch on in the first place.

46. What do we learn about singer and actress Selena Gomez in the past four and a half years?

- A) She has had worsening mental problems.
- B) She has won Instagram's most followers.
- C) She has refrained from using social media.
- D) She has succeeded in a bid on the internet.

47. Why does actively opting out of using the internet become a matter of privilege?

- A) Most people find it subtle and complicated to give up using the internet.
- B) Most people can hardly ditch the web while avoiding hate and comparisons.
- C) Most people can hardly get by without the internet due to growing digitisation.
- D) Most people have been seriously addicted to the web without being aware of it.

48. Why does the author say "witnessing companies...feels particularly irritating" (Lines 2-4, Para. 6)?

- A) The UK digital divide would further worsen due to the metaverse.
- B) The concept of the metaverse is believed to be still quite illusory.

- C) School children would be drawn farther away from the real world.
D) Most families in the UK do not have stable broadband connections.
49. What is worth bearing in mind concerning social media platforms?
A) They are conducive to promoting societal equality.
B) They help many people feel connected with others.
C) They provide a necessary device for a digital detox.
D) They create a virtual community on the internet.
50. What does the author think is really important for those living in digital exclusion?
A) Having access to the internet.
B) Edging further towards web 3.0.
C) Getting more educational resources.
D) Opening more social media accounts.

Passage Two

Questions 51 to 55 are based on the following passage.

Psychologists have long been in disagreement as to whether competition is a learned or a genetic component of human behavior. Whatever it is, you cannot but recognize the effect competition is exerting in academics and many other areas of contemporary life.

Psychologically speaking, competition has been seen as an inevitable consequence of human drives. According to Sigmund Freud, humans are born screaming for attention and full of organic drives for fulfillment in various areas. Initially, we compete for the attention of our parents. Thereafter, we are at the mercy of a battle between our base impulses for self-fulfillment and social and cultural norms which prohibit pure indulgence.

Current work in *anthropology* (人类学) has suggested, however, that this view of the role of competition in human behavior may be incorrect. Thomas Hobbes, one of the great philosophers of the seventeenth century, is perhaps best remembered for his characterization of the “natural world,” that is, the world before the imposition of the will of humanity, as being “nasty, brutish, and short.” This image of the pre-rational world is still widely held, reinforced by Charles Darwin’s highly influential work, *The Origin of Species*, which established the doctrine of natural selection. This doctrine, which takes for granted that those species best able to adapt to and master the natural environment in which they live will survive, has suggested that the struggle for survival is an inherent human trait which determines a person’s success. Darwin’s theory has even been summarized as “survival of the fittest”—a phrase Darwin himself never used—further highlighting competition’s role in success. As it has often been pointed out, however, there is nothing in the concept of natural selection that suggests that competition is the most successful strategy for “survival of the fittest.” Darwin asserted in *The Origin of Species* that the struggles he was describing should be viewed as metaphors and could easily include dependence and cooperation.

Many studies have been conducted to test the importance placed on competition as opposed to other values, such as cooperation—by various cultures, and generally conclude that Americans uniquely praise competition as natural, inevitable, and desirable. In 1937, the world-renowned anthropologist Margaret Mead published *Cooperation and Competition among Primitive Peoples*, based on her studies of several societies that did not prize competition, and, in fact, seemed at times to place a negative value on it. One such society was the Zuni Indians of Arizona, and they, Mead found, valued cooperation far more than competition. After studying dozens of such cultures, Mead’s final conclusion was that competitiveness is a culturally created aspect of human behavior, and that its prevalence in a particular society is relative to how that society values it.

51. What does the author think is easy to see in many areas of contemporary life?

- A) The disagreement on the inevitability of competition.
- B) The consequence of psychological investigation.
- C) The effect of human drives.
- D) The impact of competition.

52. According to psychology, what do people strive to do following the initial stage of their life?

- A) Fulfill individual needs without incurring adverse effects of human drives.
- B) Indulge in cultural pursuits while keeping their base impulses at bay.
- C) Gain extensive recognition without exposing pure indulgence.
- D) Satisfy their own desires while observing social conventions.

53. What do we learn about the “natural world” characterized by Thomas Hobbes?

- A) It gets misrepresented by philosophers and anthropologists.
- B) It gets distorted in Darwin’s *The Origin of Species*.
- C) It is free from the rational intervention of humans.
- D) It is the pre-rational world rarely appreciated nowadays.

54. What can we conclude from Darwin’s assertion in *The Origin of Species*?

- A) All species inherently depend on others for survival.
- B) Struggles for survival do not exclude mutual support.
- C) Competition weighs as much as cooperation as a survival strategy.
- D) The strongest species proves to be the fittest in natural selection.

55. What conclusion did Margaret Mead reach after studying dozens of different cultures?

- A) It is characteristic of humans to be competitive.
- B) Americans are uniquely opposed to cooperation.
- C) Competition is relatively more prevalent in Western societies.
- D) People’s attitude towards competition is actually culture-bound.